



MAKING DYNAMITE

In 1867, Nobel patented dynamite. Originally called “Nobel’s Safety Powder,” it was easier and safer to handle than previous explosives. One of the world’s major dynamite-producing factories was in Ardrossan, Scotland (above).



EXPLOSIVE INTENTIONS

This painting shows Nobel testing dynamite, by blowing up a ship. In 1875, Nobel invented another explosive called gelignite, which was more powerful than dynamite. In 1887, he also patented ballistite, which is still used today as a rocket propellant.

Alfred Nobel

A Swedish chemist and engineer, Alfred Nobel is best known as the inventor of dynamite, as well as other more powerful and destructive explosives. To this day, his inventions have helped to blast open mines and build canals, railways, and roads. His name lives on in the prestigious Nobel Prize, awarded annually in a number of categories, including peace.

MAN OF PEACE

In 1888, a newspaper wrongly reported Nobel had died—it was actually one of his brothers. The obituary called him “the merchant of death” because of his dangerous inventions. Upset that he might be remembered this way, he made a will that set aside a large fortune to establish the Nobel Prize.



LASTING LEGACY

The Nobel Prize is awarded annually for achievements in physics, chemistry, and medicine, all reflecting

Nobel’s scientific background. A fourth prize is for literature, and a fifth award is for a person or society that contributes to international peace.

LIFE STORY

1833

Alfred Nobel is born in Stockholm, Sweden. He is one of eight children, although only four of them—all boys—survive into adulthood.

1850

He goes to work in Paris, France, where he meets the inventor of nitroglycerin, a highly unstable explosive. He is determined to improve it.

1864

Tragically, five people, including Alfred’s younger brother Emil, are killed in an accident in a shed used for the preparation of nitroglycerin.

1867

Nobel continues with his experiments and, eventually, manufactures dynamite. He patents this invention in the US and UK.